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THE 2026-27 SEASON · ENGLAND

The Parent's Guide to Degree Apprenticeships

What they are, who pays, which schemes open when, what the application actually tests, and what you can do about it. Every number sourced.

11
applications for every Level 6 place on the government platform, 2025-26

£0
tuition paid by the apprentice. Against £47,900 of average graduate debt

7 in 10
Level 6 apprentices finish. This guide is honest about the other three

Written by Shreyash Singh, Deloitte degree apprentice 2021-25

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Two things most parents get wrong, and one that matters more than both.

The first is that a degree apprenticeship is the safe option. The second is that the money advantage is a higher salary. The third is thinking there's a deadline.

Parents tend to treat university as the ambitious route and an apprenticeship as the fallback. The evidence this season points the other way. The number of Level 6 places advertised on the government's Find an Apprenticeship service halved since 2023-24, from about 7,300 to about 3,700, while the number of applicants nearly tripled, from about 8,100 to about 21,800. That's 11.3 applications per place, up from 2.8 in 2023-24. Strip out people applying to several schemes and it's still roughly six applicants for every place. A sixth-form careers adviser quoted by the BBC tells her students it's "more competitive than many, many university degrees". She's right. The big employers run grade floors, timed cognitive tests and misconduct rules stricter than any admissions tutor.

The money case is real but it isn't the one on the posters. Graduates still out-earn school and college leaver hires at the median: £33,000 against £24,000 in the Institute of Student Employers' 2025 survey. The apprentice's advantage is different and larger. They earn that £24,000 to £32,000 for three or four years while an undergraduate earns nothing and borrows, and they finish without a Plan 5 loan taking 9% of everything above £25,000 for up to forty years. Average debt on leaving university is now £47,900. That's the number to hold in your head, not the starting salary.

And there's no deadline, which is worse than a deadline. UCAS gives you one date. Employers give you a window each, some of them sixteen days long, and every big one says it closes early when it has enough applications. Barclays opened its 2027 banking scheme on 9 September 2026 and closed it on the 25th. The City law firms open between 12 October and 1 December. Most engineering opens in January; Airbus in October. The single most useful thing a parent can do this year is make sure the application goes in during the first fortnight of each window, which means being ready before it opens.

How to use this guide. Pages 3 to 5 explain what it is and what it's worth. Pages 6 to 9 are the dates, the schemes and the process. Page 10 is the rules and the honest downside. Pages 11 and 12 are your month-by-month plan and the free resources. Page 13 is the sources, all of them, and page 14 is a link to every scheme. Where a figure covers all apprenticeship levels rather than degree level, it says so. Where a date is last season's, it says so.

WHAT IT IS

A job first. The degree comes with it.

Your child is an employee from day one, with a contract, holiday and a salary. The university place is attached to the job, and the employer pays for it.

A Level 6 degree apprenticeship is a full-time job, usually 35 to 40 hours a week, that includes a bachelor's degree from a partner university. A Level 7 includes a master's-level qualification, such as the solicitor or chartered accountant routes. They take three to five years at Level 6; the solicitor route is six. Roughly one day a week, or blocks of weeks, is study; the rest is work. At the end there's an "end-point assessment", an independent test of what they can do, graded alongside the degree. They leave with a normal classified degree, an apprenticeship certificate and, at the big firms, several years of experience their graduate peers won't have.

Older guides mention a "20% off-the-job" rule. It was replaced on 1 August 2025 by a minimum number of training hours set for each apprenticeship standard. The practical shape is unchanged.

Nobody sends you a bill. The rules explicitly prohibit any financial contribution from the apprentice. Training is paid from the employer's levy account, a 0.5% payroll tax on companies with a wage bill over £3 million, or by the government for smaller firms. From this season smaller employers pay nothing towards a new apprentice aged 16 to 24 and, from October 2026, receive a £2,000 hiring payment, which should, over time, push more places towards firms whose names you don't know yet.

The Level 7 change, and why it probably doesn't affect you

From January 2026 the government stopped funding Level 7 apprenticeships for anyone aged 22 or over at the start, except 22 to 24-year-olds with an EHC plan or who have been in care. An 18-year-old starting a solicitor or accountancy apprenticeship in September 2027 is fully funded, and some firms, Weightmans among them, now write the 16 to 21 age rule into their entry criteria. The people affected are those aged 22 and over, nine in ten of Level 7 apprentices, mostly graduates and existing employees. The one consequence for a school leaver: a plan of "Level 6 now, funded master's in my mid-twenties" no longer works unless the employer pays privately. There's no age cap on Level 6.

Two labels that mislead

"Level 6" doesn't always mean a degree. NatWest's Level 6 apprenticeship is, in its own words, "equivalent to a degree but does not include a degree". KPMG's audit apprenticeship awards the AAT and ACA accountancy qualifications, not a university degree. Deloitte's BrightStart pathways today mostly award professional qualifications rather than a university degree, so check the pathway. These are excellent routes; just know what's on the certificate. And some famous "degree programmes" are sponsored degrees, not apprenticeships. PwC's Flying Start is a four-year university degree with paid placement terms, applied for through UCAS, where the student is still a fee-paying undergraduate. Ask two questions of every scheme: what qualification is named, and who awards it.

Two questions every parent asks

Can a 17-year-old apply? Yes. Apprenticeships are open to anyone 16 or over who won't be in full-time education when they start, and applying from school is normal. What if they get nothing? Vacancies come up all year, some universities take Level 4 and 5 completers straight onto degree apprenticeships, and reapplying next September is allowed by most employers. But the pool of places fell by half in two years, so a gap year is a bet on a market that's been shrinking.

THE MONEY

Three years of pay, and no £47,900 to repay.

£9,790

Tuition fee cap for 2026-27 entry, rising with inflation again in 2027-28. Three years: £29,370 before living costs.

£47,900

Average student loan balance on entering repayment, latest cohort. Only around 55% of new starters are forecast to repay in full.

9%

Of everything earned above £25,000, deducted for up to 40 years under Plan 5. The apprentice never has it.

Put the two routes side by side for the same 18-year-old. At university they borrow up to £9,790 a year in fees and up to £10,830 a year to live on outside London, so a full three-year loan is around £60,000 before interest. On an apprenticeship they're paid. Not the legal minimum of £8.00 an hour, at the schemes in this guide, but the figures below, published by the employers themselves.

EMPLOYER	SCHEME	STARTING PAY
Slaughter and May, A&O Shearman, Linklaters	Solicitor apprenticeship, Level 7	£32,000 + £3,000 bonus
Metropolitan Police	Police Constable Degree Apprenticeship	£43,689 incl. London allowances, Sept 2026
KPMG	Audit apprenticeship	£25,500 to £28,000
JLR	Level 6 engineering, Warwick degree	£26,092
Barclays	Business Banking degree apprenticeship	£25,200
Network Rail	Level 6 engineering, BEng	£24,500
Rolls-Royce	Degree apprenticeship	£23,933, up to £39,795 by year five (finance route)

The comparison to make isn't starting salary, because a graduate at 21 will usually start on more than an apprentice did at 18. It's this: by the time the graduate starts, the apprentice has been paid for three years, has three years' seniority, and owes nothing. The one recent study that compares them a year after finishing found young degree apprentices on £36,785 against £18,555 for young graduates (the 2020-21 cohort), and the authors themselves say that isn't like for like, because apprentices already had jobs. Read it as "not behind", not as proof of a lasting lead. Nobody has ten-year data yet.

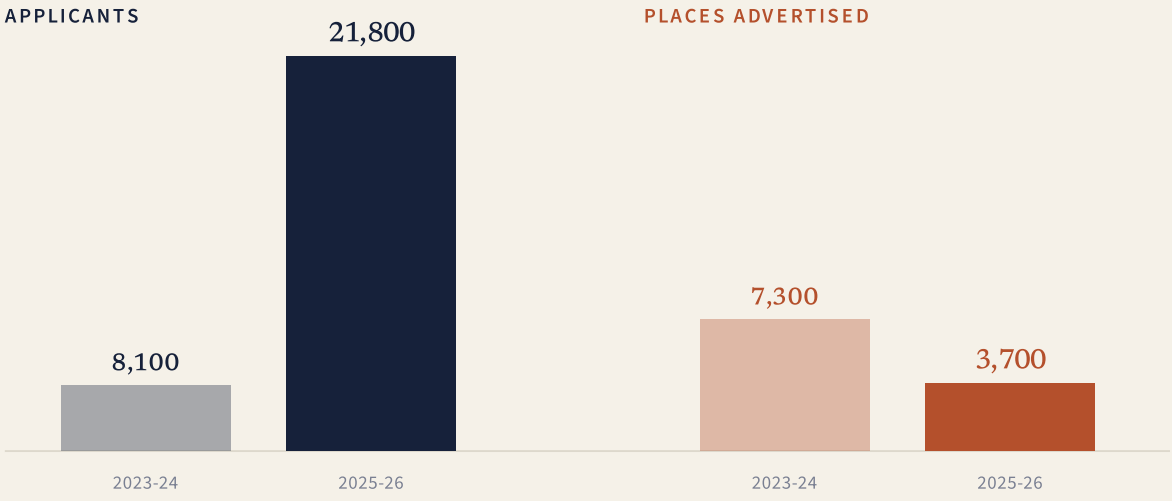
The labour market is moving the apprentice's way. Graduate hiring fell 8% last year while apprentice hiring rose 8%, a graduate role now draws 140 applications, and employers who used to hire 2.3 graduates for every apprentice now hire 1.8. Youth unemployment was 16.2% in April to June 2026. That's good for the route and bad for the odds, which is the next page.

Smaller employers can lawfully pay the £8.00 apprentice minimum, and the median degree apprentice salary across all ages was about £21,000 in 2022-23. The salary in the specific advert is the one that counts.

THE COMPETITION

Places halved. Applicants tripled.

Level 6 vacancies and applicants on the government's Find an Apprenticeship service, from a BBC freedom of information request published in August 2026.



Bars are to scale. BBC freedom of information data, government Find an Apprenticeship service, published 19 August 2026.

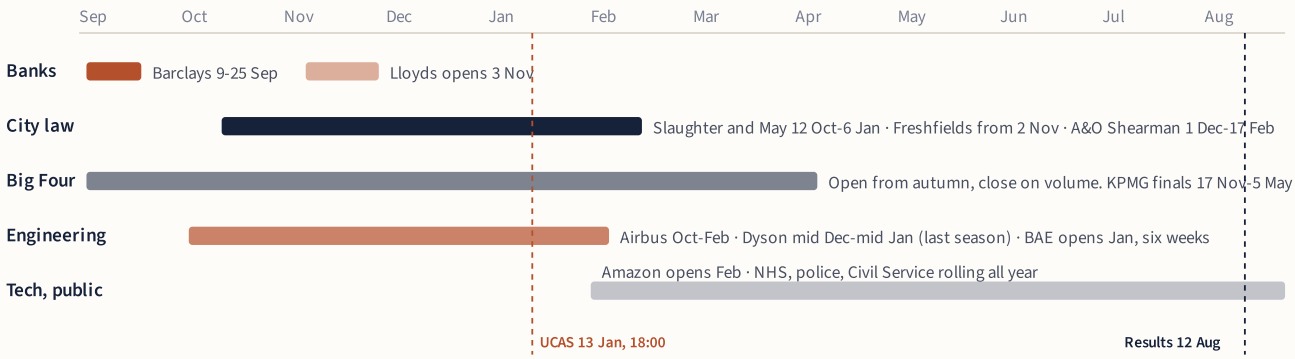
Two ways to read the same numbers. There were 42,212 applications for 3,747 places, which is 11.3 per place. There were about 21,800 people behind those applications, so each applied to roughly two schemes, and the ratio of people to places is about six to one. Both are honest. Quote them together, and remember the government platform is only part of the market: the banks, the law firms and PwC recruit through their own portals, so it understates places and demand alike. The direction is not in doubt.

Who wins? Not, on the evidence, a wider group than university. In 2022-23, 10.7% of young degree apprentices had been eligible for free school meals, below the 11.4% at Russell Group universities. Over half of all apprenticeship starts are people aged 25 or more, and a large share of Level 6 starts are existing staff being upskilled. Of 26,780 Level 6 starts last year, the 3,700 openly advertised places are the better guide to what an 18-year-old is actually competing for.

What this means for you. Treat it as applying for a competitive job while holding a university place, not as choosing between two equal options. A student with strong predicted grades at a non-selective school shouldn't assume this door is easier than the university one. It's at least as selective, and the selection starts earlier.

WHEN THINGS OPEN

There is no cycle. There are windows, and they shut early.



Confirmed 2027 dates as at 24 September 2026, with last season's pattern where employers haven't published. Bars show application windows.

Banking goes first and fastest. Barclays ran a sixteen-day window in September with "may close ahead of the advertised date due to application volumes" on the advert, so a Year 13 who wasn't ready in the first week of term has missed it; Lloyds on 3 November is the next confirmed bank date. The City law firms are the most selective and the best documented: AAB and seven GCSEs at grade 6 is the near-universal bar, the pay is £32,000 plus a £3,000 bonus, and all of them are for candidates without a degree (A&O Shearman and Linklaters say Year 13 or a school leaver); A&O Shearman and Freshfields also require three years' UK residency, and Slaughter and May the right to work for the full six years. Most engineering and car makers sit in "register your interest" mode until around January (Airbus is the exception, open from October), which means a rejection from finance or law in the autumn can be carried into a second round of applications after Christmas.

Every major employer says the same thing in slightly different words. Deloitte: "we do close applications early when we get a very high volume of submissions". EY: roles close "once positions are filled or if we receive a high volume of applications". KPMG: "some programmes fill faster than others". A candidate who applies in the first fortnight of a window can, on the published assessment dates, be holding an offer before Christmas.

Entry bars cluster. The accessible end is NatWest at 80 UCAS points, HSBC (a third-party figure) and BAE around 96, Deloitte 104, KPMG 120. JPMorgan and Amazon refuse UCAS points and want BBB or ABB with Maths or Computing. Engineering wants A-level Maths at B (JLR) or BBC with Maths and a science (Network Rail). Law wants AAB. Watch for GCSE Maths at grade 6, a quiet filter at Barclays and JPMorgan. No employer we reached advertises "no minimum grades"; the closest is KPMG, which tells applicants "a few grades or points short" to apply anyway because its contextual recruitment "may have a positive uplift".

THE SCHEMES

Thirty schemes for a September 2027 start.

Snapshot at 24 September 2026. **Confirmed** means the employer itself has published its 2027 dates; anything from a tracker is marked third party. "Last season" means expect similar timing, not a promise. Employer names are links; every address is printed on page 14.

EMPLOYER	SCHEME	ENTRY	WINDOW, SEPT 2027 START	PAY
BANKING AND FINANCE				
Barclays	Business Banking, L6	BBB; GCSE Maths 6, English 4; 3 yrs UK residency	**Confirmed** 9-25 Sep 2026; closes early on volume	£25,200
Goldman Sachs	FICC & Equities (Applied Finance, QMUL); Engineering (DTS, QMUL or Warwick). London, Birmingham	Not published; 2027 undergraduate starters	Employer: "opens autumn 2026". Intervyo lists opened 23 Sep (third party)	Not published
Lloyds	Apprenticeships incl. degree	GCSE Maths and English 4 minimum; rest per role	**Confirmed** opens 3 Nov 2026	Not published
JPMorgan	Technology L6 (Exeter); Financial Services	BBB incl. Maths/Computing; GCSE Maths 6, English 5; no UCAS points	Not yet published	Not published
HSBC	UK Degree Apprenticeship (tech, financial services); about 3 years	96 UCAS points, 5 GCSEs at 4 (third party)	Not published; last opened Jan 2024	~£24,000 (third party)
NatWest	L6 Financial Services (no degree awarded)	80 UCAS points	Not yet published	Not published
PROFESSIONAL SERVICES				
Deloitte	BrightStart, 9 pathways (mostly professional quals)	104 UCAS points, top three A-levels	2027 dates not yet published; "we do close applications early"	Not published
KPMG	Audit (AAT+ACA), Tax, Consulting, Tech	120 UCAS points; GCSE English and Maths 5; contextual	Vacancies posted individually; final-stage days 17 Nov 2026 to 5 May 2027	£25,500-£28,000 (Audit)
EY	Assurance, Consulting, EY-Parthenon, Tax (L7)	3 A-levels or 5 Highers; GCSE English and Maths 4	2027 "opens soon"; Experience Days Nov-Apr	Not published
PwC	Flying Start (sponsored degree, not an apprenticeship)	University entry grades	**Confirmed** via UCAS; bursary by 12 Mar 2027	Placement pay
Accenture	Digital & Technology Solutions BSc; L6 AI Engineer; Chartered Manager BSc	Minimum criteria; mitigating circumstances allowed	Sept 2027 confirmed, dates not yet	Not published

Three years' UK residency is a funding rule stated by Barclays, Freshfields and A&O Shearman; EY says apprenticeships carry "no visa sponsorship". Where an employer doesn't name the degree-awarding university, the Find an Apprenticeship listing must name the training provider.

Law, engineering, tech and public sector.

EMPLOYER	SCHEME	ENTRY	WINDOW, SEPT 2027 START	PAY
LAW (SOLICITOR APPRENTICESHIP, LEVEL 7, SIX YEARS)				
Slaughter and May	LLB + SQE, BPP	AAB; 7 GCSEs at 6	Confirmed 12 Oct 2026 to 6 Jan 2027	£32,000 + £3,000
Freshfields	LLB, BPP	AAB; 7 GCSEs at 6; 3 years UK residency	Confirmed opens 2 Nov 2026; site shows close "28 January 2026", presumably 2027	Not published
A&O Shearman	LLB (Hons), BPP	AAB; 7 GCSEs at 6; Year 13 or non-graduate	Confirmed 1 Dec 2026 to 17 Feb 2027	£32,000 + £3,000
Linklaters	Solicitor apprenticeship, LLB, BPP	Predicted AAB; GCSE Maths and English 4; Year 13 or school leaver	Firm not yet published; Legal Cheek lists 20 Oct 2026 to 12 Feb 2027 (third party)	£32,000 + £3,000
Pinsent Masons, Weightmans, HFW	Solicitor L7, LLB + SQE	ABB (Pinsent); 120 UCAS, 5 GCSEs at 4, aged 16-21 (Weightmans); BBB, 7 GCSEs at 4 (HFW)	Pinsent: autumn 2026. Weightmans: 28 Sep to 22 Oct (short). HFW: 1 Oct to 14 Jan, rolling (dates via Legal Cheek)	£24,479-£28,350
ENGINEERING, MANUFACTURING, INFRASTRUCTURE				
BAE Systems	L6 engineering, software, cyber, PM	96 UCAS points; 5 GCSEs incl. Maths, English; vetting	Confirmed opens Jan 2027, about six weeks	Up to £26,000
JLR	L6 engineering, BEng Warwick; L6 Digital	A-level Maths B + STEM C; 5 GCSEs at 5	2027 TBC, register interest	£26,092
Airbus	Engineering, digital, data, PM	5 GCSEs at 4 incl. Maths, English, science + A-levels	Opens Oct 2026 to Feb; "may close earlier"	Not published
Rolls-Royce	Higher and degree apprenticeships	Post A-level	Not published; Gradcracker: "opening autumn 2026" (third party)	£23,933 to £39,795
Dyson Institute	BEng, Malmesbury; apply direct, not UCAS	Not verifiable online; check the site	Last season 15 Dec to 14 Jan; offers mid April	£23,500 year 1, rising annually
Network Rail	L6 electrical, PM, digital, signalling; BEng	BBC incl. Maths + science, or DMM BTEC	Register interest for 2027	£24,500
National Grid	Higher and degree, Aston	A-levels or BTEC L3	Register interest for 2027	£24,999 (Higher route)
TECHNOLOGY, CONSUMER, PUBLIC SECTOR				
Amazon	Software Development Engineer L6, 42 months	ABB incl. Maths or Computer Science; 5 GCSEs at 4	Opens February; closes on volume	Not published
Capgemini	Digital, UX, Environmental Science DAs	3 A-levels at C; 7 GCSEs at 4	Not yet published	Not published
Unilever	L3 to L6 incl. Digital Marketing degree	Not published	2027 not yet published	£19,000-£25,000
NHS	Registered Nurse Degree Apprenticeship, L6	Level 3 plus Maths and English	Trust by trust, via NHS Jobs, all year	Trust pay band
Police forces	Police Constable Degree Apprenticeship	2 A-levels or Level 3, GCSE English 4; fitness, vetting; varies by force	Rolling; the Met starts intakes monthly	Met £43,689 incl. allowances; elsewhere from ~£34,000
Civil Service	Apprenticeships L2-7 via Civil Service Jobs	16+, nationality rules	Advertised through the year	Not published

THE PROCESS

Five stages. Most people are out before a human reads a word.

The Big Four have converged on one shape and most of the market copies it. School-leaver vacancies drew 89 applications each last year. Nobody publishes pass rates by stage, so anyone quoting one is guessing.

1 The form

Short. Deloitte's takes about fifteen minutes in one sitting; EY says a CV or cover letter "is not required", and KPMG's form asks for grades and work experience. Grades and a few motivation questions. Seventy per cent of employers screen on academics here, so this is where the biggest cut happens, silently.

Where it goes wrong. Missing the grade line. Getting a grade wrong (PwC checks academics later in the process). A typo in the email address, or a school email that blocks recruiters. Applying to two programmes when only one per cycle is allowed. EY makes you wait three months after a rejection.

2 Online tests

Two parts. An untimed situational test where they rank responses to workplace scenarios, and a timed numerical and verbal test. KPMG's timed section is 36 minutes. PwC uses numerical, inductive and deductive tests on the SHL platform.

Where it goes wrong. Second-guessing the situational test. Deloitte's own recruiters: "go with your gut instinct, don't try to second guess what it is we might be looking for." The timed test is the one place practice honestly helps; the untimed one punishes it.

3 Recorded video interview

Questions appear on screen, they get preparation time, then record an answer. KPMG's are delivered by an AI avatar and "reviewed and scored by a member of our Student Recruitment team". PwC says "we do not use AI to assess candidate performance". Humans watch these.

Where it goes wrong. Generic motivation. KPMG wants "a real passion for the programme, business area and location you've applied to", and a rehearsed answer about "the company's values" isn't that. Rambling past the timer. Reading from notes off screen.

4 The assessment centre

Ninety minutes to half a day. In person at Deloitte and KPMG, virtual at PwC, either at EY. A group exercise, a case study or written task, sometimes a presentation, and an interview. Deloitte's final stage is 80 to 90 minutes with a topic discussion that requires pre-reading. KPMG's "Launch Pad" makes an offer within two working days.

Where it goes wrong. Dominating the group rather than contributing to it. Turning up without the mandatory research. Summarising before two people have spoken. Employers told the ISE that 54% of their new graduate hires fell short on self-awareness and 46% on resilience; that's what the interviewer is probing.

5 Offer, conditions, results day

Offers arrive between February and April, earlier at the fastest employers (KPMG's first final events are in November), conditional on A-level grades, and the grades are a condition of the job, not just the university place. Contracts and background checks follow in May and June. Results are confirmed with the employer directly, not through UCAS.

Where it goes wrong. Missing grades and calling the university first. The university can only lower its bar "with employer approval", so on the morning of 12 August the employer is the first call.

THE RULES

Help they can't accept.

The Big Four sit in the strict camp, and the reason matters. Across the 155 employers the ISE surveyed in 2025, only one in ten bans AI outright, but 85% found suspected cheating, most often "candidates using AI during interviews without disclosure or permission", and four in five are redesigning or reviewing their process because of it.

PwC prohibits "AI tools, AI-enabled services, or any third-party assistance" in assessments and reserves the right to tell "professional bodies, regulatory organisations". KPMG requires every assessment to be done "without the assistance of others, or any artificial intelligence". EY suspends any assessment where "there is any suspicion that you are receiving help".

"Assistance of others" includes you. A parent who drafts an answer creates a mismatch that the human-scored video interview and the half-day centre are designed to find. For an accountancy or law apprentice, a report to a professional body can follow them into their career. Proofread for accuracy. Don't write.

Adjustments, asked for early

If your child has exam access arrangements, ask for the equivalent at the application stage, not after a poor timed test. Deloitte needs no formal diagnosis or proof and offers extra time, a no-self-view option on video, quiet breaks and pre-visits. EY offers up to 25% extra time and doesn't require medical evidence. KPMG asks you to declare before each stage. A child on an assessment waiting list is covered.

THE HONEST DOWNSIDE

Seven in ten finish. The degree depends on the job.

The Level 6 achievement rate was 69.3% in 2024-25, the highest of any apprenticeship level and up from 57.3% three years earlier; for 16 to 18-year-old starters it was 71% in 2023-24, the latest year analysed. Three in ten still don't finish, and the reasons aren't mostly academic. In a 2022 survey of earlier cohorts, 44% of Level 6 and 7 non-completers cited the workload, against 28% at other levels (a small sample, so a signal rather than a measure). A full-time job and a degree at once is, for many 18-year-olds, the hardest thing they've done. Ask any employer for its own completion rate and how study time is protected.

The structural risk is one no salary table shows. The degree is funded through the employer. Leave voluntarily and there's no right to keep the funded place. Made redundant and there's a twelve-week window to find another employer; Open University researchers found the rules leave "many dedicated and keen apprentices unable to complete their apprenticeship". Read the contract for stay-or-repay clauses; nobody publishes how common they are.

Choice is narrow. Health, construction, digital, business and law, and engineering are 96% of young Level 6 starts. Humanities, pure science and the creative subjects barely exist. Three in five would-be applicants gave up because they couldn't find one where they live.

And the ground moves. Level 7 was defunded for over-21s in January, a Level 6 management standard lost funding in March, and 42% of employers expect to cut Level 7 hiring. Treat this as a flat or shrinking market for open places, which is also an argument against a gap year on the assumption of a better field next time.

> The good news, at the right level: 83% of degree apprentices were still with their employer after finishing, the highest retention of any group. Nobody has followed them for ten years yet.

YOUR YEAR

Month by month. Two fixed dates, everything else moves.

UCAS equal-consideration deadline: **13 January 2027, 18:00**. A-level results: **Thursday 12 August 2027**. UCAS itself tells parents to run a university application in parallel. Nearly a third of parents in a 2021 UCAS survey didn't know you could.

Year 12 spring and summer	HAPPENING Employer insight days for Year 12 run and fill early. PwC's is paid and eligibility-gated. Springpod's virtual work experience is free and certificated, with Airbus, Barclays, NHS and Rolls-Royce among partners.	YOU Get one week at a small firm, arranged by your child's own email. Complete one virtual programme. Draft a CV. Open Find an Apprenticeship and UCAS Hub accounts. Ask the school's careers leader what apprenticeship support exists; the law requires one.
September	HAPPENING Banking opens and closes. Barclays 9 to 25 September; Goldman Sachs from 23 September. EY and KPMG rolling windows live.	YOU GCSEs, predicted grades and CV to hand before term. Apply in the first fortnight of any window. Register interest on every "TBC" employer page so the opening email arrives.
October, November	HAPPENING Slaughter and May opens 12 October. Airbus opens. Freshfields 2 November, Lloyds 3 November. KPMG's first final event 17 November. EY Experience Days begin.	YOU Check eligibility line by line: GCSE Maths at 6? Three years' residency? Proofread for accuracy, not prose. Request adjustments now. Free practice tests before the timed stage.
December, January	HAPPENING A&O Shearman opens 1 December. Slaughter and May closes 6 January. BAE opens in January for six weeks. Dyson ran mid December to mid January last season. **UCAS closes 13 January.**	YOU Submit UCAS whatever they prefer. Mock interviews at home: situation, task, action, result, using real examples from the work experience. Expect silences of two days to eight weeks between stages.
February to April	HAPPENING Amazon opens. A&O Shearman closes 17 February. Assessment centres peak. First conditional offers. KPMG final events in Bristol, Glasgow and London. PwC bursary deadline 12 March.	YOU Read any offer for its grade conditions and what happens if they're missed. Don't touch UCAS offers until the apprenticeship offer is in writing. Keep applying to the later engineering and rolling public-sector schemes.
May, June	HAPPENING A-level exams. Contracts, references and background checks arrive from employers.	YOU Take the admin off their desk during exams. Make sure the school knows who gives an employment reference; it isn't the UCAS one.
12 August	HAPPENING Employer and university confirm directly. University-side offers may follow 24 hours after results.	YOU If grades are missed, your child phones the employer that morning before anything else. Only the employer can approve a lower bar.
September 2027	HAPPENING Employment starts early to mid September. University enrolment in the first weeks.	YOU Budget on the advertised salary after tax and National Insurance. They're an employee now, not a student.

FREE, AND ENOUGH

You can build the whole toolkit for nothing.

VACANCIES

A Find an Apprenticeship account with saved searches and alerts. UCAS Career Finder, free to students because employers pay to list. Intervyo's finance tracker, Gradcracker for STEM, Higherin's search.

UNDERSTANDING IT

Amazing Apprenticeships' Parent Zone: a parent and carer guide, the monthly Choices magazine, the Parent Perspective podcast, a step-by-step application guide. UCAS's parent guide and its "How I Got My Apprenticeship" case studies. The National Careers Service on 0800 100 900 for a neutral adviser.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Springpod's free ten-hour virtual programmes. Forage. In-person Year 12 placements from BAE Systems, Deloitte, EY Foundation, HSBC, KPMG, PwC and Slaughter and May, check each one's closing date early in the spring term.

TESTS

One free test in every format at Practice Aptitude Tests; Pro is £39 a year if they want more. Each employer's own practice materials, which Deloitte hosts in its free Candidate Zone.

PAID HELP

A market with prices and no evidence.

UK career coaching runs at £75 to £120 a session for CV work, £120 to £250 for full career coaching, and £400 to £2,000 for packages. No independent study shows any of it improves a school leaver's odds. Deloitte is blunt: "there are some websites offering assessment insights for a fee. These are not endorsed by Deloitte and often provide misleading or false information. We will never charge for assessment advice."

The legal line is the Employment Agencies Act 1973. An employment agency commits an offence if it charges a work-seeker a fee "for the purpose of finding him employment or seeking to find him employment". A coach isn't automatically an agency, but a provider whose fee depends on your child getting the job is operating on that line.

Red flags

"Guaranteed placement." Fees contingent on an offer. Ghost-written applications, which build the mismatch employers now screen for. Coaches who won't name who they are or what they've assessed. No refund terms. "Free consultations" that are sales calls.

What's defensible

Practice under real conditions, with someone who's sat on the other side of the table: a timed test, a recorded interview played back, a mock assessment centre. Bought once, when your child has reached that stage, because everything before it is free. The test of any provider is simple: would they help just as much if the answer to "did they get in?" had no effect on what you pay?

WHERE THIS GUIDE COMES FROM

I applied from sixth form at 17 with nobody to practise against, got a Deloitte degree apprenticeship, and spent four years watching who didn't and why. Get In is a two-day course that runs every stage on page 9 under real conditions, scored the way employers score it. This guide is complete without it. The details are on the back page.

SOURCES

Every number, and where it came from.

All accessed 24 September 2026. England unless stated. Figures marked "all levels" cover every apprenticeship level, not only degree level.

Competition. BBC freedom of information data on Find an Apprenticeship, reported by Personnel Today, 19 Aug 2026 (applicants 8,100 to 21,800; places 7,300 to 3,700; 11.3 applications per place) and BBC via AOL, 19 Aug 2026 (42,212 applications, 3,747 positions). Unique-applicant ratio is our arithmetic from the two.

Fees and loans. Prospects, student loans and finance, Apr 2026 (£9,790 cap; maintenance maximums; Plan 5 terms). House of Commons Library CBP-10155, 8 Jul 2026 (future fee rises). Commons Library SN01079, 18 Aug 2026 (£47,900 average balance; ~55% forecast to repay in full).

Salaries. Employer pages: Slaughter and May; A&O Shearman; Linklaters; JLR; Barclays job advert; KPMG Audit apprenticeship; Network Rail early careers; Rolls-Royce apprenticeships (Apr 2026). Police pay: Metropolitan Police PCDA page, Sept 2026 (£43,689 including allowances); national constable pay point 0 from September 2026 via policepay.co.uk (third party). Apprentice minimum wage: FE Week, 25 Nov 2025. Median degree apprentice salary 2022-23: Commons Library CBP-8741, 8 May 2024.

Graduate comparison. Institute of Student Employers, 15 Oct 2025 (median £33,000 vs £24,000; vacancies -8%/+8%; 140 applications per graduate role; ratio 2.3:1 to 1.8:1). Education Policy Institute, A decade of degree apprenticeships, 12 Nov 2025 (£36,785 vs £18,555 one year on, with its own caveat; sector shares; FSM 10.7% vs 11.4%; 71% achievement for 16-18 starters). Commons Library SN05871, 18 Aug 2026 (youth unemployment 16.2%).

What it is and who pays. Commons Library CBP-8741 (definition, contracts, no fees). DfE apprenticeship funding rules 2026-27 v3, 29 Jul 2026 (section "Financial contributions by an apprentice"; Level 7 age rule, para 32; co-investment and £2,000 payment). DfE off-the-job training guidance v6, Aug 2026 (end of the 20% rule). GOV.UK end-point assessment guide, 7 Feb 2024. HEPI, 21 Oct 2025 (89% of Level 7 apprentices aged over 22). Weightmans solicitor apprenticeship page (16-21 entry condition). NatWest, KPMG, Deloitte and PwC Flying Start pages for the labelling points.

Schemes table. Each employer's early-careers page, plus Goldman Sachs' EMEA degree apprentices page and Intervyo's finance tracker, UCAS employer profile (HSBC), Legal Cheek's solicitor apprenticeship deadlines (Weightmans, HFW, Linklaters; third party), Civil Service Careers and the withdrawn GOV.UK Fast Track page, Dyson Institute applying page and FAQ (last season's dates; £23,500 salary). Every link is printed on page 14.

Process. Deloitte early careers assessment page (five steps, "close early", "gut instinct", adjustments, paid-advice warning). KPMG application process and advice pages (36-minute test, avatar interview human-scored, Launch Pad dates, AI rule, contextual recruitment). PwC assessment and selection page (SHL tests, no AI scoring, third-party ban, grade verification). EY schools page and FAQs (no CV, close on volume, three-month wait, 25% extra time, no visa sponsorship). Mott MacDonald apprenticeships page. ISE Student Recruitment Survey 2025 (89/61 applications per school-leaver vacancy; 70% academic screen; 52% video; 63% assessment centre; AI and cheating figures; campaign timing). ISE top 10 stats 2025 (self-awareness 54%, resilience 46%, graduate data). Higherin assessment centre advice.

Outcomes. FE Week, 26 Mar 2026 (2024-25 achievement rates: Level 6 69.3%, all levels 65.4%). DfE Apprenticeship Evaluation 2023, learner and non-completer surveys, Sept 2024 (95% in work, 83% retention for degree apprentices, withdrawal reasons; all levels). St Martin's Group, Oct 2022 (workload 44% vs 28%). Open University SCiLAB, 22 Nov 2023 (redundancy and the degree). UCAS and Sutton Trust, 6 Jul 2023 (three in five couldn't find one locally). Times Higher Education, 30 Mar 2026 (defunding). Sutton Trust, 8 Dec 2022 (participation). DfE Apprenticeships 2024-25, updated 29 Jan 2026 (starts by level and age).

Your year. UCAS 2027 entry deadline page (13 Jan 2027, 18:00). AQA results days table (A-level results 12 August 2027). The Apprentice Route timeline, checked 24 Jul 2026 (offers conditional). Ulster University results day guide (employer approval for reduced entry). UCAS apprenticeship FAQs and parent guide. UCAS, Feb 2021 (a third of parents unaware). GOV.UK Become an apprentice (age 16+). Careers and Enterprise Company apprentice guide, Jan 2026 (statutory careers leader).

Resources and paid help. findapprenticeship.service.gov.uk; UCAS Career Finder; Amazing Apprenticeships Parent Zone; Education Hub, Feb 2024 (National Careers Service number); Springpod; Prospects Year 12 work experience, Jul 2026; practiceaptitudetests.com. Hula Career, 29 Jul 2026 (advertised coaching prices; the article offers no effectiveness data). Employment Agencies Act 1973, s.6, legislation.gov.uk.

Get In is independent. It is not affiliated with any employer, university or scheme named here. Employers make every hiring decision; nothing in this guide promises an outcome. Dates change: check the employer's page before planning around any date in this guide.

EVERY SCHEME, ONE LINK

Where to apply, and where to look.

Employer pages first, checked 24 September 2026. If a link has moved, search the employer's name with "apprenticeship" and "early careers". Then the free places to search and prepare.

Barclays
search.jobs.barclays/job/london/2027-business-banking-degree-apprenticeship-programme-london/13015/100411086720

Goldman Sachs
www.goldmansachs.com/careers/students/programs-and-internships/emea/degree-apprentices

Lloyds
www.lloydsbankinggrouptalent.com/our-opportunities/apprenticeships/

JPMorgan
www.jpmorganchase.com/careers/explore-opportunities/programs/technology-degree-apprenticeship

HSBC
www.hsbc.com/careers/students-and-graduates/schools-and-apprenticeships/degree-apprenticeships

NatWest
jobs.natwestgroup.com/pages/degree-apprenticeships

Deloitte
www.deloitte.com/uk/en/careers/early-careers/early-careers-programmes.html

KPMG
www.kpmgcareers.co.uk/apprentice/

EY
www.ey.com/en_uk/careers/students/schools

PwC
www.pwc.co.uk/careers/early-careers/our-programmes/flying-start-degrees.html

Accenture
www.accenture.com/gb-en/careers/local/apprenticeships

Slaughter and May
www.slaughterandmay.com/careers/early-careers/solicitor-apprenticeship-programme/

Freshfields
www.freshfields.com/en/your-career/united-kingdom/early-careers/solicitor-apprenticeship-program

A&O Shearman
careers.aoshearman.com/en/london-solicitor-apprenticeships

Linklaters
www.linklaters.com/en/careers/early-careers/school-opportunities

Pinsent Masons
www.pinsentmasons.com/careers/early-talent/england/apprenticeships/solicitor

Weightmans
www.weightmans.com/careers/early-careers/apprenticeships/solicitor-degree-apprenticeship/

HFW
www.hfw.com/careers/early-careers/early-careers-london/early-careers-solicitor-apprenticeship/

BAE Systems
careers.baesystems.com/locations/uk/apprentices/degree

JLR
careers.jaguarlandrover.com/early-careers/apprentices/level-6-applied-professional-engineering-programme-degree-apprenticeship

Airbus
www.airbus.com/en/careers/students-and-graduates/apprentices/apprenticeships-in-the-united-kingdom

Rolls-Royce
careers.rolls-royce.com/en/students-and-graduates/united-kingdom/apprenticeships-and-school-leavers

Dyson Institute
www.dysoninstitute.ac.uk/undergraduate-programme/applying/

Network Rail
www.earlycareers.networkrail.co.uk/scheme/level-6-electrical-and-electronic-engineer-apprenticeship/

National Grid
careers.nationalgrid.com/new-talent/apprentices/higher-degree-apprenticeships

Amazon
amazonapprenticeships.co.uk/our-programmes/software-development-engineer-apprentice

Capgemini
www.capgemini.com/gb-en/careers/career-paths/graduates-and-apprenticeships/apprenticeships/

Unilever
careers.unilever.com/en/uk-and-ireland-early-careers-apprenticeships

NHS
www.healthcareers.nhs.uk/explore-roles/nursing/how-become-nurse

Police forces
www.met.police.uk/police-forces/metropolitan-police/areas/c/careers/police-officer-roles/police-constable/overview/entry-routes/police-constable-degree-apprenticeship-pcda/

Civil Service
www.civil-service-careers.gov.uk/apprenticeships/

Search and prepare, free

Find an Apprenticeship (GOV.UK)
www.findapprenticeship.service.gov.uk/

UCAS apprenticeships
www.ucas.com/apprenticeships

UCAS parent and carer guide
www.ucas.com/apprenticeships/parent-carer-and-guardian-guide-to-apprenticeships

Amazing Apprenticeships Parent Zone
www.amazingapprenticeships.com/zones/parent/

National Careers Service
nationalcareers.service.gov.uk/

Springpod virtual work experience
www.springpod.com/virtual-work-experience

Practice Aptitude Tests
www.practiceaptitudetests.com/

Higherin (formerly RateMyApprenticeship)
higherin.com/

Gradcracker (STEM)
www.gradcracker.com/

Intervyo finance tracker
www.intervyo.co.uk/tracker/finance-degree-apprenticeship

Legal Cheek solicitor apprenticeship deadlines
www.legalcheek.com/solicitor-apprenticeships/

Get In

ENTRANCE PREPARATION FOR DEGREE APPRENTICESHIPS

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Two days in London. Timed tests marked and explained. A recorded video interview, scored and played back. A full mock assessment centre. Their real application reviewed twice. A score for every stage, before and after, so you can see what moved.

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Free

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